THE COLD WAR

BAY OF PIGS



Date April 17, 1961
Forces Americans/Cuban exiles: 1 aircraft carrier, 6 destroyers, 4 freighters, 2 landing craft; Cubans: 15,000 men
Losses Americans/Cuban exiles: 1 freighter sunk; Cubans: unknown

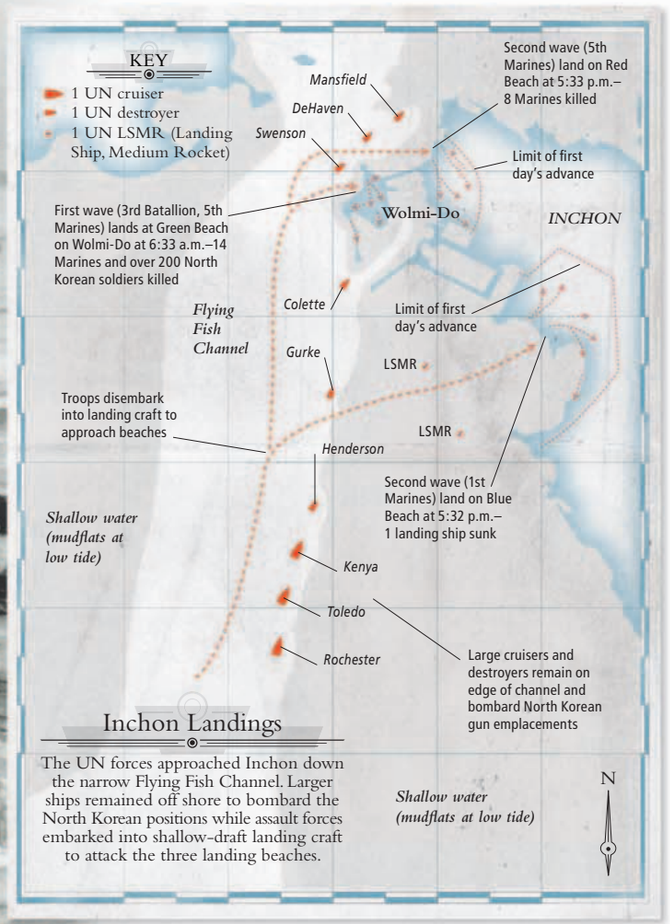
Location Off coast of southwest Cuba

In the early 1960s, with Communist dictator Fidel Castro firmly in power in Cuba, relations between the United States and its Caribbean neighbor were deteriorating fast. In 1961 the US government decided to pursue a military solution. The Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) trained a group of 1,500 Cuban exiles for an invasion of Cuba, with the aim of removing Castro from power. The exiles were to land at the Bay of Pigs in four freighters, alongside two CIA landing craft, with heavy air and fire support from the US carrier *Essex* and six US Navy destroyers.

The landing force went in on April 17, 1961. Air strikes destroyed initial Cuban resistance and the landing was successful. However, the invasion force was subsequently destroyed over three days of fighting, to the embarrassment of the US government. Four US pilots also died during engagements over Cuba and Cuban strike jets managed to sink one enemy freighter.

a risky foray into the Flying Fish Channel to test North Korean defenses. When shore guns opened up, revealing their location, these were destroyed by air attack and salvoes from cruisers.

On the night of September 14–15 US Marines traveled toward Wolmi-do on board the high-speed destroyers *Bass*, *Diachanko*, and *Wantuck*, preceded by a destroyer escort, followed by large landing craft with heavy equipment, and covered by a force of cruisers. The Marines transferred to landing craft and went ashore at first light, exploiting the morning flood tide. An intense naval bombardment ensured that resistance was slight. The follow-up landings, to the north and south of Wolmi-do, had to wait for the late afternoon tide. The North Koreans proved unable to mount a swift counterattack, however, and by around 5:30 p.m. Marines were swarming up ladders over seawalls in Inchon itself. Marine casualties on the day amounted to 22 killed and 174 wounded. The success of the landings led to the recapture of the South Korean capital Seoul and obliged North Korean forces to retreat northward in an effort to avoid encirclement. It also unfortunately tempted MacArthur to take the war into North Korea, leading to the involvement of Chinese troops and a bloody stalemate lasting into 1953.





US blockade of Cuba
Soviet tanker *Polzunov* is inspected by the US Navy picket ship *Vesole* as it carries a cargo of ballistic missiles away from Cuba on November 9, during the Soviet withdrawal of missiles from the island.

THE COLD WAR

CUBAN MISSILE CRISIS



Date October-November 1962
Forces Americans/Allies: 183 warships; Soviets: unknown
Losses Americans/ Allies: none; Soviets: none

Location Atlantic, northeast of Cuba

From the summer of 1962, Soviet engineers and scientists began work on the Communist-controlled island of Cuba, establishing medium-range ballistic missile launch facilities. By using Cuba as a nuclear missile launch-pad, the USSR could target almost the whole of the southern United States. When the facilities were revealed by U-2 reconnaissance flights over the island in October 1962, the deployments terrified the US authorities.

The US government of John F. Kennedy opted to take a tough stance against the Soviets, issuing a demand that the missiles and their facilities be withdrawn from Cuban soil immediately, and threatening a nuclear response against the Soviet Union should it attempt any open aggression. The stakes were raised when the United States, with maritime support from Venezuela, Argentina, and Dominica, imposed a naval blockade off Cuba with warships, aircraft carriers, and nuclear-armed submarines. On October 24, the blockade faced its first major challenge with the approach of 19 cargo ships, mostly containing missile equipment, shadowed by Soviet submarines. A dramatic stand-off ensued, which finally resolved itself when most of the Soviet ships turned around in the face of US intransigence.

Only one Soviet ship, the tanker *Bucharest*, managed to make it through to Havana. Tensions escalated and for a time the world teetered on the brink of nuclear war. Ultimately, however, the US naval blockade effectively convinced the Soviet government under Nikita Khrushchev that Cuba was not a viable investment for missile defense, and it agreed to remove the missile sites from Cuba under UN inspection. The naval blockade of Cuba was finally lifted on November 20.



Submarine Geiger counter
The US deployed nuclear submarines during the Cuban blockade. Geiger counters such as this one were used to check levels of radiation in the vessels and monitor how much radiation had been absorbed by crews.

> "THE SOVIET GOVERNMENT CANNOT INSTRUCT THE CAPTAINS OF SOVIET VESSELS BOUND FOR CUBA TO OBSERVE THE ORDERS OF THE AMERICAN NAVAL FORCES BLOCKADING THAT ISLAND."
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> **NIKITA KRUSHCHEV, SOVIET PREMIER,** LETTER TO US PRESIDENT JOHN F. KENNEDY